

Support Services and Customer Experience Analysis

January 2025 through September 15, 2026 | 21 calendar months, including a partial September

Executive Summary

Northstar's support operation handled 9,690 tickets during the review period. The dominant operating trend is sustained demand growth: completed month ticket volume increased from 267 in January 2025 to 589 in August 2026, a 121% increase, while the number of employees handling support remained in a narrow 18 to 20 range. Despite that growth, overall service performance remained broadly stable. Among resolved tickets, 91.3% met SLA, average resolution time was 11.78 hours, and the overall escalation rate was 7.1%.

The aggregate performance masks several persistent risks. High-priority tickets are the clearest service weakness, meeting SLA on 84.4% of resolved work and escalating on 29.9% of tickets. Customer experience data shows why that matters: CSAT averaged 4.09 when SLA was met versus 2.98 when missed, and fell to 3.51 once resolution exceeded 24 hours. Mid-Market customers also create materially more support demand per account than smaller segments, increasing the importance of segment-aware capacity planning. The data does not support one simple root cause; category mix, channel, employee tenure, and staffing count each explain only part of the operating picture.

9,690	91.3%	11.78 hrs	4.00
tickets reviewed	resolved-ticket SLA	average resolution	average CSAT

Recommended Priorities

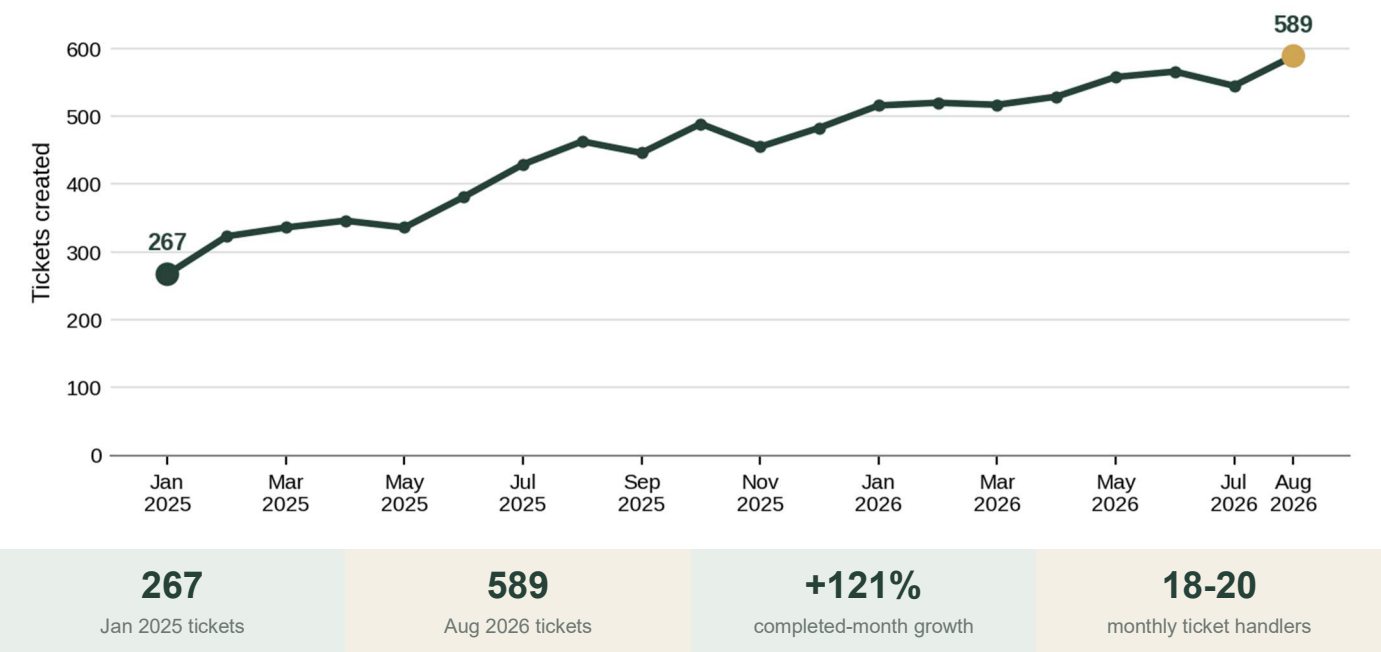
- Build a demand capacity model that combines ticket volume, arrival rate, priority mix, customer segment, open work aging, staffing, leave, absence, and training time.
- Manage high priority work as a distinct service risk with standing review of misses, escalations, aging, and root causes.
- Track customer-impact measures with operating measures so SLA misses, 24+ hour resolution, repeat issues, and communication problems remain visible to leadership.
- Incorporate segment level support demand into customer planning and account economics, particularly for Mid Market customers.

1. Demand and Capacity Trends

The full-period story begins with demand. Ticket volume increased steadily across the completed months of the review period, while the pool of employees handling support remained relatively flat. Service quality did not deteriorate in proportion to volume, but the operating model is carrying materially more work than it did at the start of the period.

Support demand more than doubled across completed months

Monthly ticket volume | January 2025 through August 2026



Leadership Implication

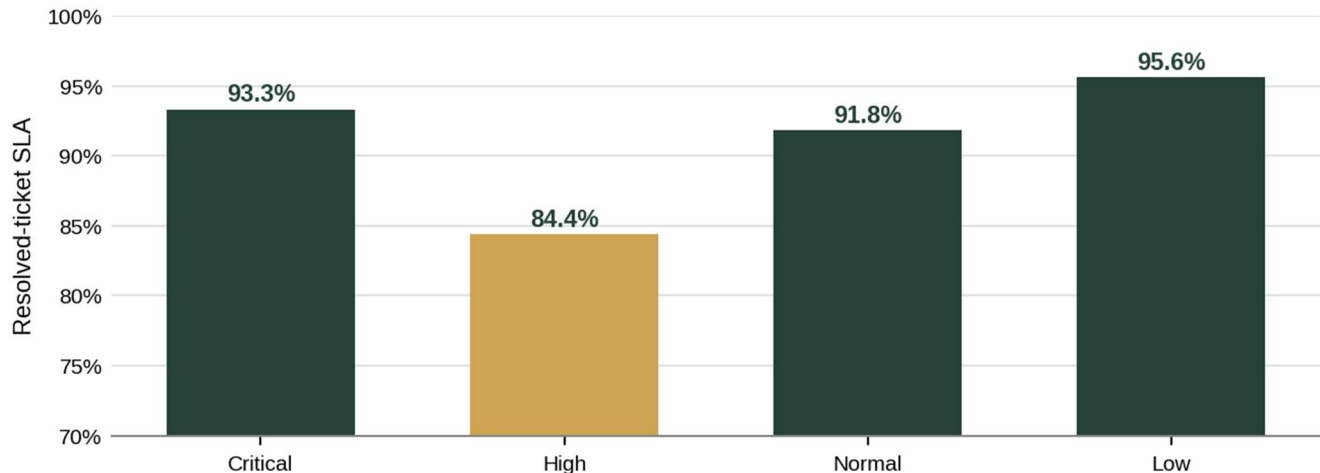
The service organization has absorbed substantial demand growth without a broad collapse in SLA or resolution time. That is a positive operating result, but it also means historical staffing levels should not be assumed to remain sufficient. Capacity planning should be forward-looking and based on demand, not simply on whether current SLA still appears acceptable.

2. Service Performance by Priority

Priority is the clearest performance discriminator in the support data. High-priority work consistently performs below the other service levels and carries a much higher escalation burden than Normal or Low-priority tickets.

High-priority tickets are the persistent SLA weakness

SLA attainment among resolved tickets | Full review period



Priority	Tickets	Share	SLA target	Avg. resolution	Resolved SLA	Escalated
Critical	362	3.7%	4 hrs	1.75 hrs	93.3%	27.3%
High	1,664	17.2%	8 hrs	5.11 hrs	84.4%	29.9%
Normal	5,857	60.4%	24 hrs	11.79 hrs	91.8%	1.3%
Low	1,807	18.6%	48 hrs	19.89 hrs	95.6%	0.9%

High-Priority Risk

High-priority tickets represent 17.2% of total volume. Average resolution is 5.11 hours against an 8-hour SLA, yet only 84.4% of resolved tickets meet SLA. The average therefore masks a meaningful tail of late work. High-priority escalation is 29.9%, reinforcing the need to manage this queue separately from the overall SLA rate.

Recommended Action

- Review High-priority misses and escalations monthly by category, age, handoff, and resolution path.
- Add High-priority aging and oldest-open work to the operating review so averages do not hide late-ticket risk.

3. Category and Repeat-Issue Patterns

No single issue category dominates support demand. Each major category represents roughly one-tenth of total tickets, which argues against a single product defect or queue explaining the overall workload. Category differences are more useful for targeted improvement than for explaining total service pressure.

Category	Tickets	Share	Avg. hrs	Resolved SLA	Escalated
Security/Permissions	1,028	10.6%	11.90	92.1%	7.2%
Workflow/Configuration	984	10.2%	11.83	90.9%	7.3%
Data Import	983	10.1%	12.19	89.7%	8.6%
Integration/API	982	10.1%	11.78	91.9%	6.8%
Access/Login	981	10.1%	11.51	91.5%	7.4%
Feature Guidance	973	10.0%	11.28	90.7%	7.1%
Billing Question	956	9.9%	11.71	90.9%	7.6%
Performance	944	9.7%	11.79	92.0%	6.5%
Reporting	933	9.6%	11.85	91.6%	7.7%
Bug	926	9.6%	11.99	91.8%	4.9%

Data Import carries the highest overall escalation rate at 8.65% and the lowest category-level resolved SLA at 89.7%, but the differences across categories are relatively narrow. The more actionable signal appears in repeat-issue feedback rather than raw category volume.

Repeat-Issue Signal

Category	Repeat-issue surveys	SLA miss	Escalated	Avg. resolution
Workflow/Configuration	17	47.1%	29.4%	22.23 hrs
Performance	13	38.5%	23.1%	12.33 hrs
Reporting	13	30.8%	23.1%	16.23 hrs

Workflow/Configuration stands out within the repeat-issue survey subset, with a 47.1% SLA miss rate, 29.4% escalation, and 22.23-hour average resolution. The sample is small, so this should be treated as a focused root-cause lead rather than a population-level conclusion.

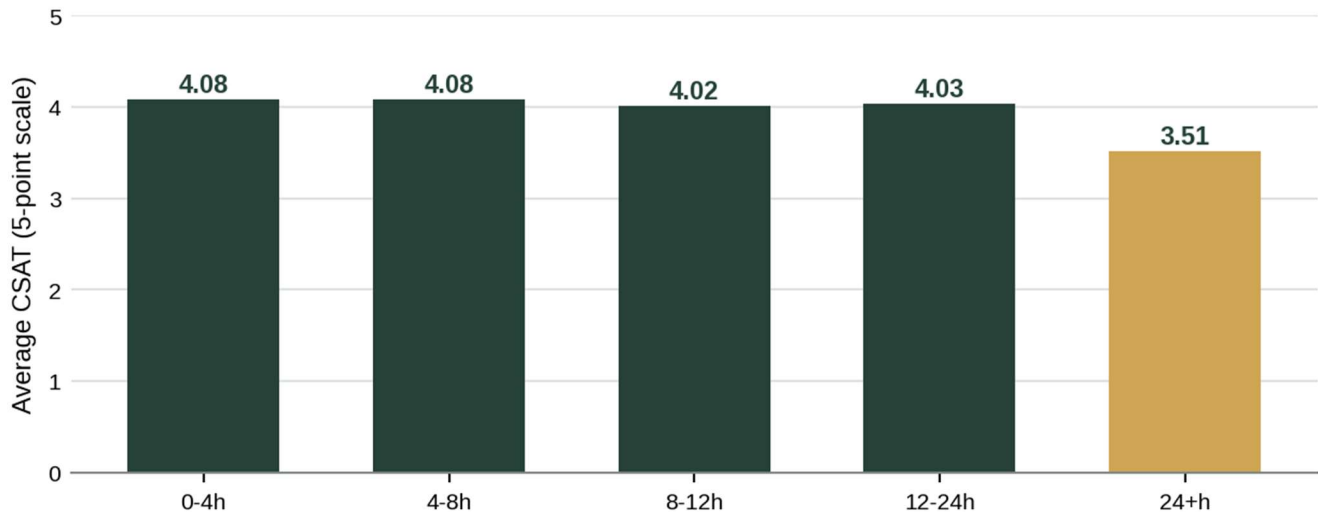
4. Customer Experience

Customer satisfaction is strongly associated with service execution. SLA misses, escalation, and extended resolution time all correspond with materially lower CSAT, while priority itself has much less effect on satisfaction.

4.09 CSAT when SLA met	2.98 CSAT when SLA missed	4.04 CSAT not escalated	3.45 CSAT escalated
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Customer satisfaction drops when resolution exceeds 24 hours

3,282 satisfaction surveys matched to support tickets



Negative theme	Surveys	Avg. CSAT	SLA miss	Escalated
Resolution Time	171	2.85	31.0%	14.6%
Product Complexity	148	2.88	20.3%	16.2%
Repeat Issue	148	2.89	25.7%	16.2%
Communication	137	2.91	29.9%	13.9%
Implementation Gap	121	2.91	28.1%	14.0%

Leadership Implication

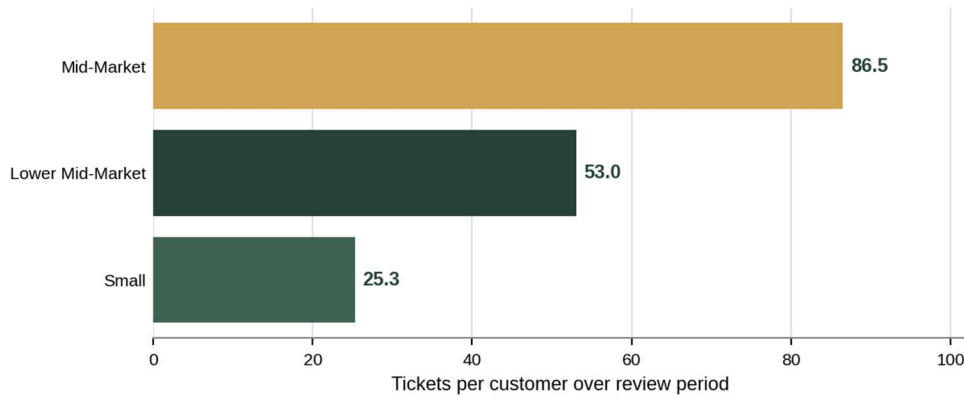
The customer signal is consistent: delay, escalation, repeat work, and communication friction have a measurable experience cost. Service reporting should therefore pair throughput and SLA with 24+ hour work, escalation, repeat-issue themes, and CSAT rather than treating closure volume as the primary definition of performance.

5. Customer Segment Demand

Support demand is materially different by customer segment. Larger customers generate more tickets and more High-priority work per account, even though average satisfaction remains nearly identical across segments.

Mid-Market customers create more than three times the demand of Small accounts

Average tickets per customer | Full review period



Segment	Customers	Tickets	Tickets / customer	High / customer	High SLA	Avg. CSAT
Small	115	2,906	25.3	4.1	84.0%	3.99
Lower Mid-Market	79	4,189	53.0	9.6	84.2%	4.02
Mid-Market	30	2,595	86.5	14.6	81.3%	3.99

Mid-Market customers generated 86.5 tickets per customer during the review period, compared with 53.0 for Lower Mid-Market and 25.3 for Small customers. They also generated 14.6 High-priority tickets per customer, roughly 3.6 times the Small-customer rate. Because CSAT remains near 4.0 across segments, the primary issue is support consumption and capacity, not segment-specific dissatisfaction.

Recommended Action

- Use tickets per customer and High-priority demand per customer in capacity and account-planning models.
- Review whether support assumptions, service tiers, and Customer Success coverage reflect the materially higher operating demand of Mid-Market accounts.

6. Operational Patterns and Root-Cause Testing

The analysis tested several plausible explanations for performance variation. None explains the support operation by itself. This matters because the data does not support attributing the service challenge to one shift, one employee group, one channel, or one issue category.

Hypothesis tested	What the data showed	Conclusion
Channel mix	Phone, Portal, and Email each average about 11.6-12.0 hours; resolved SLA ranges only 91.2%-91.5%.	Not a material driver.
Employee tenure	Tenure differences largely disappeared after controlling for ticket priority and category.	Turnover matters for stability, but newer staff are not a proven ticket-level cause.
Ticket category	Volume is evenly distributed across categories; 24+ hour work is also broadly distributed.	No single queue explains the operating pattern.
Shift / raw workload	Off-hour performance is weaker in some periods, but workload per person and staffing count do not consistently predict SLA.	Coverage should be monitored, but raw headcount alone is not an explanation.
Customer concentration	Long-duration and surge demand is distributed across customers; concentration did not increase during the September event.	Not driven by a small number of accounts.

Workforce Context

The companion Workforce and Operational Risk Analysis identified a 75.8% period turnover rate in the 24/7 Service Desk, the company's highest overtime rate, schedule pressure, lean Overnight coverage, and materially lower Overnight training completion. Those findings are relevant because they reduce operating flexibility, but the support data does not establish that any one workforce measure directly caused ticket-level SLA misses.

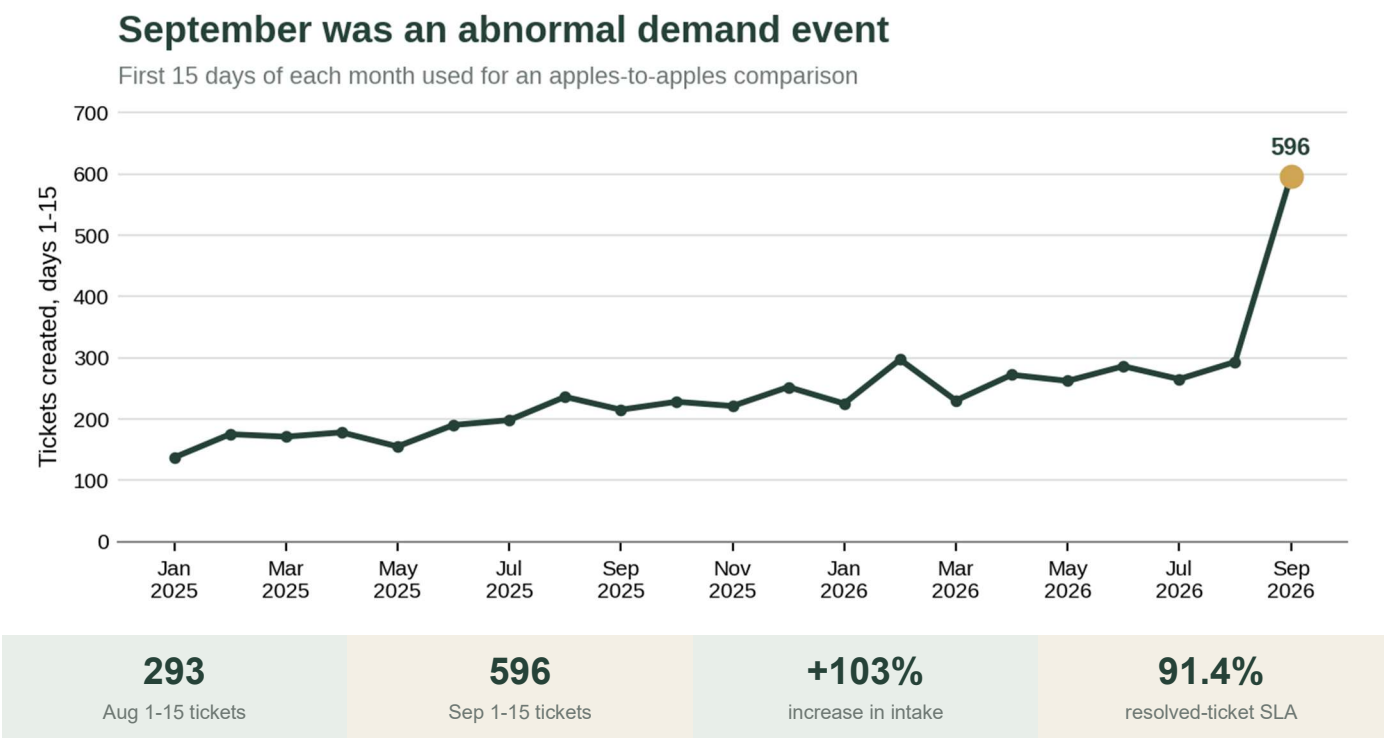
75.8% 24/7 Service Desk turnover	2.79% Service Desk overtime	62.5% Overnight training completion	7 schedule-related exits
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What the combined evidence supports

Northstar has a capacity and resilience risk: support demand is growing, High-priority work is less reliable, and the Service Desk is operating alongside documented workforce instability. The appropriate response is integrated capacity management, not a single-cause staffing conclusion.

7. Advanced Finding: September 2026 Stress Event

September is included here as an advanced finding because it stress-tested the support model under abnormal demand. It is not used as the basis for the executive summary or the full-period trend conclusions. The dataset ends on September 15, so the comparison below uses the first 15 days of each month.



The surge was broad rather than concentrated. The top 10 customers represented 18.3% of September-window tickets, down from 21.8% in the comparable August period. Category mix also remained broadly similar. Product-usage data shows customer count and licensed seats unchanged, active users essentially flat (-0.5%), and API calls up about 6.1%, which does not provide a single clear business explanation for the increase.

At the reporting cutoff, 94 September tickets remained open. These are open work at a partial-period cutoff, not automatic SLA failures. Among resolved September tickets, overall SLA remained 91.4%, while High-priority SLA was weaker at 78.4%. The value of the event is operational: it shows the need for surge thresholds and response procedures when arrival rates move sharply outside the normal range.

8. Action Plan

The recommended plan addresses the recurring findings first and treats unusual demand surges as a separate operating scenario.

Timing	Action	Owner	Expected outcome
0 to 30 days	Build a Service Desk demand-capacity model using ticket volume, arrival rate, priority mix, customer segment, open-work aging, leave, absence, training time, and minimum shift coverage.	CTO / Service Desk Director / People	Staffing and coverage decisions tied to sustained workload and service requirements.
0 to 30 days	Separate resolved-ticket SLA, High-priority SLA, open-ticket aging, throughput, and escalation in monthly service reporting.	Service Desk Director / Analytics	Earlier visibility into queue pressure and time-sensitive service risk.
0 to 45 days	Establish a standing High-priority review for misses and escalations with root cause, owner, and corrective action.	Service Desk / Product / Customer Success	Reduced avoidable delay and escalation on time-sensitive work.
0 to 45 days	Add segment-level support demand to customer capacity and account-planning reviews.	Customer Success / Service Desk / Finance	Planning reflects the higher support consumption of larger accounts.
30 to 60 days	Investigate recurring repeat-issue and communication themes, beginning with Workflow/Configuration and Data Import.	Service Desk / Product / Customer Success	Fewer repeat contacts and preventable customer friction.
30 to 60 days	Define surge thresholds, triage rules, and cross-trained coverage for abnormal intake periods.	CTO / Service Desk Director	A repeatable response before open work or High-priority risk accumulates.
60 to 90 days	Establish a monthly cross-functional service review combining support, customer experience, workforce capacity, and product signals.	Executive Leadership / Functional Leaders	Sustained visibility and accountability across service operations.

Monthly Service Review

- Ticket volume, arrival rate, throughput, and open-work aging.
- Resolved-ticket SLA, High-priority SLA, escalations, and 24+ hour resolution.
- CSAT, customer effort, repeat issues, and communication themes.
- Demand by customer segment and account concentration.
- Staffing capacity, overtime, absence, training time, and shift coverage.
- Surge events, cross-functional causes considered, assigned actions, and follow-through.

Methodology

This analysis used 9,690 Northstar support tickets created from January 1, 2025 through September 15, 2026, with resolution activity recorded through September 17, 2026; 3,282 customer satisfaction surveys; customer and product-usage data; and findings from the companion Workforce and Operational Risk Analysis. Data was staged and analyzed in MariaDB, with additional validation performed against the source CSV files.

SLA performance is calculated on resolved tickets only. Tickets still open at the reporting cutoff are reported separately and are not automatically treated as SLA failures. Completed-month trend charts use January 2025 through August 2026. September is a partial month and appears only in aggregate period measures where appropriate and in the advanced stress-event analysis, which uses the first 15 days of each month for a comparable time window.

Customer-segment measures use unique customers and ticket volume over the review period. Customer-experience results use satisfaction surveys matched to ticket records. Root-cause tests were used to challenge plausible explanations including channel, employee tenure, category mix, shift, staffing level, and customer concentration. Where the available data did not support a hypothesis, it was not retained as a causal finding.

Conclusion

Northstar Support Services is not defined by one failing queue or one bad month. The durable story is a service organization absorbing substantially more demand while maintaining broadly stable overall performance. The primary recurring risk is High-priority work, and the customer data shows that SLA misses, escalation, and extended resolution time carry a measurable satisfaction cost. Larger customer segments also consume materially more support capacity per account.

The leadership response should therefore focus on demand-capacity planning, High-priority service management, segment-aware support planning, and direct monitoring of customer-impact measures. Workforce instability should be incorporated into that operating model as a resilience factor, while avoiding unsupported conclusions that turnover, tenure, or one shift alone caused service outcomes. The September stress event reinforces the value of a defined surge response, but it does not change the full-period conclusions.

Northstar IT is a fictional business environment created for a professional portfolio case study.